

HEAVY MACHINE-GUNS

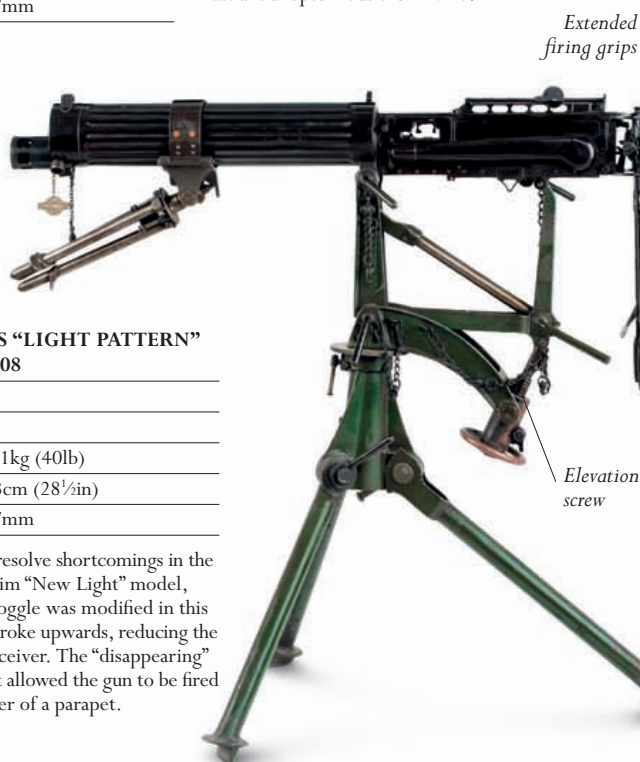
The most significant and deadly weapons used on the battlefield in World War I, “heavy” machine-guns accounted for more casualties than any other weapons except for artillery. They were capable of maintaining sustained fire for hours on end so long as simple precautions were observed, such as changing barrels regularly. Sited to cover vulnerable features, these guns usually operated in batteries, firing through fixed, interlocking arcs. When combined with barbed wire, they made it almost impossible for infantry to advance without taking enormous losses. Only with the development of effective armoured fighting vehicles (AFVs) was their omnipotence overcome.



▲ VICKERS-MAXIM “NEW LIGHT” MODEL 1906

Date 1906
Origin UK
Weight 19.6kg (43½lb)
Barrel 72.3cm (28½in)
Calibre 7.7mm

The first departure from Maxim’s original design, the “New Light” saw the original brass fittings exchanged for much lighter steel, but continued to employ the downwards-breaking locking toggle that made the receiver large. The Russians adopted it as the M1910.



► VICKERS “LIGHT PATTERN” MODEL 1908

Date 1908
Origin UK
Weight 18.1kg (40lb)
Barrel 72.3cm (28½in)
Calibre 7.7mm

Designed to resolve shortcomings in the Vickers-Maxim “New Light” model, the locking toggle was modified in this gun: it now broke upwards, reducing the size of the receiver. The “disappearing” tripod mount allowed the gun to be fired from the cover of a parapet.

► DWM MG08
Date 1908
Origin Germany
Weight 26.5kg (58½lb)
Barrel 71.9cm (28¼in)
Calibre 7.92mm Mauser

Soon after the German army acquired its first Maxims in 1895, Deutsche Waffen und Munitionsfabriken (DWM) began modifying the design, and the final version was adopted as the *schweres Maschinengewehr 08*. It had a heavy sledge-style mount, known as the *Schlitten*.



► RUSSIAN MAXIM M1910
Date 1910-42
Origin Russia
Weight 23.8kg (52½lb)
Barrel 72.1cm (28½in)
Calibre 7.62mm

The Imperial Russian arsenal at Tula began manufacturing the Vickers “New Light” model in 1910; it stayed in production until 1942. They were mounted on Sokolov wheeled carriages, which incorporated a turntable, while some, such as this one, were fitted with shields.



► SCHWARZLOSE M07/12
Date 1912
Origin Austria-Hungary
Weight 19.9kg (43¾lb)
Barrel 52.6cm (20¾in)
Calibre 8mm Mannlicher

The Schwarzlose was the only heavy machine-gun to use an unlocked “blowback” system, better suited to pistol-calibre ammunition, relying on a very heavy breechblock and return spring to slow the rate of fire. Massively over-engineered, it proved almost indestructible in normal use.

